

Session 6: Jesus Fulfills the Torah

Key Takeaways

- Jesus does not reject the laws of the Hebrew Bible. Instead, he follows the tradition of the Hebrew prophets who point to the need for a new covenant and a new heart so that people can follow the laws.
- Jesus teaches that even the smallest commands of the Torah are part of God's will for his people. They point beyond individual behaviors to deeper heart change and a greater vision for what his Kingdom is like.

A Righteousness that Fulfills the Torah & Prophets

Matthew 5:17-20

Jesus fills-full the Torah

- **5:17** Jesus has come to **fill-full (πληρώω)** the Torah and Prophets
- **5:18-19** The Torah's commands are authoritative and to be kept *during this age*
- **5:20** Jesus' apprentices are to do-what-is-right in a way that **far surpasses (περισσεύω)** Israel's current leaders

Matthew 5:21-47

Six case studies in filling-full the Torah

- Case study 1: Murder & anger
- Case study 2: Adultery & lust
- Case study 3: Divorce & remarriage
- Case study 4: Oaths & truth-telling
- Case study 5: Retaliation & nonviolence
- Case study 6: Loving your enemy

Matthew 5:48

Conclusion

- Become **complete-whole (τέλειος)**, as your Father in the skies is complete

Matthew 5:17-48. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus Fulfills the Torah

17 Don't suppose that I have come to **do away with** the **Torah (νόμος)** **or the Prophets** .
I have not come to **do away with** ,
but to **fill them full (πληρώω)** .

- a 18 **Because**, truly, I tell you:
b **until** **the sky** and the land pass on,
c not one dot or one squiggle will pass on from the **Torah** ,
b' **until** all things have taken place.

- a 19 **Therefore**, whoever **undoes** one of the least of **these commands** ,
b and then they teach people to do this,
c that person will be called least in **the kingdom of the skies** .
a' And whoever does [**these commands**],
b' and then teaches [people to do this],
c' this person will be called great in **the kingdom of the skies** .

20 **Because**, truly, I tell you:
unless your **doing-of-what-is-right** **far surpasses (περισσεύω)**
that of the **Scribes** and **Phariseaions** ,
you won't be entering into **the kingdom of the skies** .

Matthew 5:17-20. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

In this paragraph, Jesus anticipates a host of criticisms from his fellow Israelite rabbis about the relationship of his teachings to the covenant commands in the Torah. Jesus anticipates such objections and then responds with the six case studies that will follow in [5:21-48](#). The phrase “do not suppose” assumes that some of Jesus’ contemporaries were confused or concerned by Jesus’ exalted claims about himself and his authority in relation to the Torah. These concerns will grow into a full-on conflict with the scribes and Pharisees as Matthew’s account develops.

Jesus’ Sabbath practices and his disputes about the “traditions of the fathers”:

Matthew 12:2 Instructor's Translation

But when the Pharisees saw this, they said to him, “Look, your disciples do **what is not-authorized [by the Torah]** to do on a Sabbath.”

Matthew 15:1-2 Instructor's Translation

Then some Pharisees and scribes came to Jesus from Jerusalem and said, “Why do your disciples **break the tradition of the elders?** For they do not wash their hands when they eat bread.”

We know that Jesus’ followers were later subject to the same criticism from their Jewish compatriots.

Acts 6:11 Instructor's Translation

We have heard [Stephen] speak blasphemous words **against Moses and against God.**

Acts 6:13-14 Instructor's Translation

This man [Stephen] incessantly speaks **against this holy place and the Torah;** for we have heard him say that this Nazarene, Jesus, will destroy this place and alter the customs which Moses handed down to us.

Acts 21:28 Instructor's Translation

[Paul] is the man who preaches to all men everywhere **against our people and the Torah and this place;** and besides he has even brought Greeks into the temple and has defiled this holy place.

The rhetorical design of Jesus’ words invites us to compare the various parts of the statement that are linked by parallelism and wordplay.

- The opening “do away with” (Greek: *kataluo*) links forward to “undoes” (Greek: *luo*) in that both words come from the same root. Jesus does not at all want to be associated with Jewish movements that abandon Torah-faithfulness. Just the opposite, he claims that his teaching is, in fact, the “fulfillment” of the Torah and Prophets. However, what exactly does it mean to be faithful to a fulfilled Torah and Prophets? This is what Jesus will turn to in the paragraphs that follow.
- Do away with (*kataluo*) = dismantle, dissolve, abolish, destroy a building [See word study list below.] To do this to an authoritative text is to declare it is no longer valid. The issue is the relationship of his claims and teachings to the existing authority of Scripture.

The potent but ambiguous “fill them full” (Greek: *plerosai*, often translated “fulfill”) of the Torah is matched by the “far surpasses” (Greek: *periousai ... pleion*). In other words, the fulfillment of the Torah and Prophets will be a kind of behavior that surpasses other contemporary interpretations of the Torah. This is what Jesus is going to describe in [5:21-48](#) in six case studies. And the sixth and final case study links back to this idea: “And if you greet only your brothers, what more (Greek: *perisson*) are you doing than others?” ([5:47](#)).

Matthew 24:2 NASB

And he said to them, “Do you not see all these things? Truly I say to you, not one stone here will be left upon another, which will not be **kataluo**.”

Matthew 26:61 NASB

and said, “This man stated, ‘I am able to **kataluo** the temple of God and to rebuild it in three days.’”

Acts 5:38-39 NASB

So in the present case, I say to you, stay away from these men and let them alone, for if this plan or action is of men, it will be **kataluo**; but if it is of God, you will not be able to **kataluo** them; or else you may even be found fighting against God.

Romans 14:20 NASB

Do not **kataluo** the work of God for the sake of food. All things indeed are clean, but they are evil for the man who eats and gives offense.

“Fulfill Them” (Plerao)

Jesus’ fulfillment is contrasted with “do away with,” which shows the issue is not just observance or obedience to the Torah (in which case, he would say, “I haven’t come to abolish, but to teach obedience to Torah”). Rather, the issue is about the role that the Torah and Prophets play within the ongoing purpose of God now that Israel’s messiah has arrived.

“Fulfill” has been used already by Matthew in chapters 1-4, showing how Jesus is bringing the story of the Scriptures and of Israel to its culminating fulfillment or purpose: Jesus is bringing about that to which Scripture pointed.

Matthew 1:22–23 NIV

All this took place **to fulfill what the Lord had said through the prophet**: “The virgin will conceive and give birth to a son, and they will call him Immanuel” (which means “God with us”).

Matthew 2:14–15 NIV

So he got up, took the child and his mother during the night and left for Egypt, where he stayed until the death of Herod. And so was **fulfilled what the Lord had said through the prophet**: “Out of Egypt I called my son.”

Matthew 2:16–18 NIV

When Herod realized that he had been outwitted by the Magi, he was furious, and he gave orders to kill all the boys in Bethlehem and its vicinity who were two years old and under, in accordance with the time he had learned from the Magi. Then what was said through **the prophet Jeremiah was fulfilled**: “A voice is heard in Ramah, weeping and great mourning, Rachel weeping for her children and refusing to be comforted, because they are no more.”

Matthew 2:22–23 NIV

But when he heard that Archelaus was reigning in Judea in place of his father Herod, he was afraid to go there. Having been warned in a dream, he withdrew to the district of Galilee, and he went and lived in a town called Nazareth. So was **fulfilled what was said through the prophets**, that he would be called a Nazarene.

Matthew 3:13–15 NIV

Then Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan to be baptized by John. But John tried to deter him, saying, “I need to be baptized by you, and do you come to me?” Jesus replied, “Let it be so now; it is proper for us to do this **to fulfill all righteousness.**” Then John consented.

Matthew 4:12–16 NIV

When Jesus heard that John had been put in prison, he withdrew to Galilee. Leaving Nazareth, he went and lived in Capernaum, which was by the lake in the area of Zebulun and Naphtali— **to fulfill what was said through the prophet** Isaiah:

“Land of Zebulun and land of Naphtali, the Way of the Sea, beyond the Jordan, Galilee of the Gentiles—the people living in darkness have seen a great light; on those living in the land of the shadow of death a light has dawned.”

Notice that “fulfillment” has to do with the prophets, which is exactly what Jesus says in 5:17. In other words, Jesus reads the Torah and Prophets as a unified whole that reaches forward to something that needs to be fulfilled.

Israel’s inability to fulfill their role as Yahweh’s covenant partners is a major theme in the Torah and Prophets. Specifically, the scriptural narrative shows that Israel consistently fails to live faithfully by Yahweh’s wise covenant commands. All of the major prophets anticipate a day when that inability will be reversed.

Isaiah 50:4 NASB

The Lord God has given me the tongue of **disciples**,
that I may know how to sustain the weary one with a word.
He awakens me morning by morning,
he awakens my ear to listen as a **disciple**.

Isaiah 51:7 NASB

Listen to me, **you who know righteousness**,
a people **in whose heart is my Torah**;
do not fear the reproach of man,
nor be dismayed at their revilings.

Isaiah 54:13 NASB

All your sons will be taught/disciples of the LORD;
and the well-being of your sons will be great.

Jeremiah 31:33–34 NASB

“But this is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days,” declares the LORD,
“I will put my Torah within them and on their heart I will write it;
and I will be their God, and they shall be my people.
They will not teach again, each man his neighbor
and each man his brother, saying,
‘Know the LORD,’
for they will all know me,
from the least of them to the greatest of them,” declares the LORD,
“for I will forgive their iniquity,
and their sin I will remember no more.”

Ezekiel 36:26–28 NASB

Moreover, I will give you **a new heart and put a new spirit** within you; and I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh.

I will put my Spirit within you and cause you to walk in my statutes,

and you will be careful to observe my ordinances.

You will live in the land that I gave to your forefathers;

so you will be my people, and I will be your God.

These key prophetic texts are in the immediate background of Jesus' claim to "fulfill" the Torah and the Prophets. In the sermon, Jesus is announcing that he is bringing in the new era of fulfillment to create a renewed Israel that will be transformed by God's Spirit to become faithful covenant partners.

"The one who fulfills the law and prophets displaces them in so far as he must become the center of attention."

Davies, W. D. & Allison, Dale C., Jr. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 487.

"Fulfill" here doesn't simply mean how Jesus relates to the Torah and its observance, but rather the way Jesus fulfills a pattern and purpose laid down in the Torah and Prophets themselves.

Note that Jesus fulfills "law and prophets," so the question isn't just about Torah observance but about how he brought all of Scripture to its culminating purpose.

Matthew 5:17-21 is a four-part statement that moves forward in a logical progression:

1. Assertion (5:17): I haven't come to set aside Torah-faithfulness. Rather, my teachings call people to fulfill what the storyline of the Torah and Prophets are all about.
2. Because (5:18 = logical grounds for the previous statement): The Torah is an eternal statement of the divine will for Israel. It will never be non-relevant for the people of God.
3. Therefore (5:19 = the logical conclusion of the above statement): The Torah has abiding divine guidance to offer God's people. How someone responds to that guidance plays a determining role in one's standing before God.
4. Because (5:20 = the logical grounds for the above statement): One's standing before God is determined by an even greater standard of Torah-faithfulness than what is currently being taught by Israel's religious leaders.

This paragraph is anticipating a possible objection to the teaching and authority of Jesus that is presumed in the stories of Matthew 4:23-5:2, and specifically his teaching about the Torah.

"[Matthew] 5:17-19 ... anticipates an incorrect interpretation of 5:21-48, ... and it states in advance the truth, which is that Jesus comes not to abolish but to fulfill the law. Positively, 5:20 announces what 5:21-48 is really all about, the greater righteousness ..."

Allison, Dale C., Jr. (2005). [*Studies in Matthew: Interpretation Past and Present*](#). Baker Academic. 181.

Paraphrase of Matthew 5:17-20

“Far from wanting to set aside the Torah and Prophets, it is my role to bring into being that to which they have pointed forward, to carry them into a new era of fulfillment.” (From R.T. France, [Matthew](#))

Interpretive Notes on Matthew 5:17-20

Matthew 5:17 Instructor's Translation

Because truly I tell you:

until **the sky** and the land **pass on**,
not one dot or one squiggle will **pass on** from the **Torah**,
until all things have taken place.

“truly I say” = *amen lego*

- This use of amen is unique to Jesus. There is no evidence of any other Jewish teacher who talked like this. Amen = true, reliable, faithful. Jesus says it 30 times in Matthew, particularly in teachings that he expects people to find surprising or uncomfortable.

“until heaven and earth pass away”

- The biblical authors sometimes contrast Yahweh’s eternal nature to the passing nature of the cosmos. But their point is to highlight the creator/creation distinction and the superior value of God’s creating word. The purpose of the statement is not to predict the dissolution of the universe.

Psalms 102:25–27 NIV

In the beginning you laid the foundations of the **land**, and the **skies** are the work of your hands.

They may perish, but you remain; they will all wear out like a garment. Like clothing you will change them and they will be discarded.

But you remain the same, and your years will never end.

Isaiah 51:6 NIV

Lift up your eyes to the heavens, look at **the land beneath; the skies will vanish like smoke, the land will wear out like a garment** and its inhabitants die like flies. **But my salvation will last forever**, my righteousness will never fail.

Isaiah 54:9–10 NIV

“To me this is like the days of Noah, when I swore that the waters of Noah would never again cover the earth. So now I have sworn not to be angry with you, never to rebuke you again.

Though the mountains be shaken and the hills be removed, yet my unfailing love for you will not be shaken nor my covenant of peace be removed,” says the LORD, who has compassion on you.

It is common in the Hebrew Bible to compare God’s covenant promises to the enduring order of creation.

Psalms 89:35–37 NIV

Once for all, I have sworn by my holiness—and I will not lie to David—that his line will continue forever and his throne **endure before me like the sun;**

it will be **established forever like the moon**, the faithful witness in the sky.

Jeremiah 31:35–37 NASB

Thus says the LORD,
who gives the sun for light by day
and the fixed order of the **moon** and the **stars** for light by night,
who stirs up the **sea** so that its waves roar;
the LORD of hosts is his name:

“If this fixed order departs

From before me,” declares the LORD,
“then the offspring of Israel also will cease
from being a nation before me forever.”

Thus says the LORD,
“If the heavens above can be measured
and the foundations of the earth searched out below,
then I will also cast off all the offspring of Israel
for all that they have done,” declares the LORD.

Jeremiah 33:19–21 NIV

The word of the LORD came to Jeremiah:
“This is what the LORD says: ‘If you can break **my covenant with the day and my covenant with the night**,
so that day and night no longer come at their appointed time,
then my covenant with David my servant—and my covenant with the Levites who are priests ministering
before me—can be broken and David will no longer have a descendant to reign on his throne.

“Until all things have taken place” (ἕως ἃν πάντα γένηται)

- Why two “until” clauses? If you take either one away, the sentence makes sense. Is the authority of the Torah permanent (first until clause), or will its authority change once “all things come to pass” (second until clause)?
- The two “until” clauses are not in competition but form a restatement and clarification of [5:17](#). The implied verb in the second until clause is not “pass away” (the jots and tittles are not discarded in what Jesus came to do). Rather, “all things coming to be” is a reference to “fulfill” in 5:17, and speaks of eschatological fulfillment.
- “all things coming to pass” reoccurs in [Matt. 24:34-35](#).
- “Heaven and earth” passing away refers to the passing of the current world order. “All things” refers to the same, but highlighting God’s redemptive purposes.

Paraphrase of Matthew 5:18

“The Torah, down to its smallest details, is more permanent than heaven and earth, and will never lose its significance; on the contrary, all that it points forward to will in fact become a reality.” (R.T. France, [Matthew](#))

Now that Jesus has brought the fulfillment, the details of Torah will be seen in a new light, but they cannot be discarded.

The burden of [5:21-47](#) will be to illustrate how the laws may function in this new role, where they serve not as a binding rule of conduct but as pointers to a “greater righteousness” that Jesus is bringing into being.

- *iota* (“smallest letter, jot”) = *yod*: smallest Hebrew Letter.
- *keraiā* (lit. “horn”) denotes the small projection that distinguishes *aleth* and *resh*, or *heh* and *taw*, or *beth* and *kaph*.

Conclusions About Matthew 5:18

Jesus is not offering a prediction about a future catastrophic disintegration of the cosmos. He’s using a figure of speech to heighten the importance of God’s will revealed in the Torah: God’s word in the Torah is, by definition, more enduring than what God created by that word (the land, skies, seas, lights).

Even if creation were to disintegrate, God’s word, which authored order and integration, will not pass away.

Jesus is raising the stakes on the importance of God’s will revealed in the Torah (a point with which many Jewish teachers of his day would agree) and then taking the next step. But what kind of behavior truly does conform to God’s will? This is what he’s about to address in [5:21-48](#).

Greatest and Least in Matthew 5:19

Matthew 5:19 Instructor's Translation

Therefore, whoever **undoes** one of the least of these **commands**,
and then they teach people to do this,
that person **will be called least** in the **kingdom of the skies**.
And whoever **does** [the **commands**],
and then teaches [people to do this]
this person **will be called great** in the **kingdom of the skies**.

The emphasis here is not on the doing of the commands of the Torah as such but on someone teaching others to do or not do the commands of the Torah.

“The issue is ... not primarily obedience to the commandments, but undermining their authority by teaching that they can now be ignored. ... Behavior is not excluded, of course ... but it is teaching the value of the commandments which is the true converse of setting them aside. ... But are the commandments to be ‘done’ in the same way as before Jesus came? In the light of the emphasis on fulfillment which has introduced this passage and which will be central to what follows we can only suppose therefore that [Jesus] had in mind a different kind of ‘doing’ from that of the scribes and Pharisees, a ‘doing’ appropriate to the time of fulfillment. That will mean, in effect, the keeping of the law as it is now interpreted by Jesus himself, and it will be the role of [vv. 20–48](#) to explain what this means in practice. See further [Matthew 28:20](#), where it is the ‘commandments’ of Jesus, not those of the Torah, which are to be the basis of Christian discipleship.”

France, R. T. (2007). [The Gospel of Matthew, The New International Commentary on the New Testament](#). Eerdmans. 187-188.

That last comment by France, “not those of the Torah,” is a bit too strong, in my view. Notice that Jesus derives his own “and I say to you” teachings by means of wisdom reflection on the laws of the Torah. It is precisely the commands of the Torah that invite the disciples of Jesus to meditate on the deeper wisdom underneath the command that points to new ways of “fulfilling” its moral vision. One needs both the command itself (“you have heard it said”) and Jesus’ exposition (“and I say to you”) to carry forward Jesus’ commission in Matthew 28:20.

Greatest or Least in the Kingdom

“The graphic language derives from a play on words between the ‘smallest’ commandments and the ‘smallest’ reputation of the careless disciple. It is not helpful to press it into supporting a view of the kingdom of heaven as a social structure within which there are first- and second-class citizens, a view which Matthew seems at pains to discourage in the parable found in 20:1–16, not to mention the idea that the greatest in the kingdom of heaven are the lowest (see 18:1–4 and 20:25–27). The dynamic sense of the kingdom of heaven as God’s rule suggests rather that to be called great or small in the kingdom of heaven means to be high or low in God’s esteem, to be a more or less worthy representative of those who acknowledge him as king.”

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew, The New International Commentary on the New Testament*](#). Eerdmans. 188.

Righteousness in Matthew 5:20

Matthew 5:20 Instructor's Translation

Because truly I tell you:

unless your **doing-what-is-right** **far surpasses** that of the **scribes** and **Pharisees**,
you won't be entering into the **kingdom of the skies**.

For Matthew, the word “righteousness” has the same meaning it does in the Hebrew Bible (to do *tsedeq/tsedaqah* צדק/צדקה): To do right by someone; treating another person in a generous, equitable way that is appropriate to the relationship.

In Matthew’s ethical worldview, this means doing right by one’s neighbor, which is at the same time doing right by God. It is human action that aligns with the will of God.

Love Fulfills the Torah

Matthew 5:17-20 introduces a theme that is picked up again in Matthew’s account, in 22:35-40.

Matthew 22:35–40 Instructor's Translation

One time, a Torah-scholar asked him a question, testing him,
“Teacher, which is the great **commandment** in **the Torah**?”

And he said to him, “You shall **love** the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind.”

This is the great and first **commandment**.

The second is like it, 'You shall **love** your neighbor as yourself.'

On these two **commandments** depend **the whole Torah and the Prophets**."

In Jesus' mind the twin-call to love and devote oneself to God and one's neighbor is the heartbeat of all of the commands in the Torah, but also the essence of the Torah and Prophets. This idea in Jesus' teaching was developed in the teaching of the apostles and in the broader context of Second Temple Judaism.

Galatians 5:14 NASB

For the whole **Torah is fulfilled** in one word, in the statement, "You shall **love** your neighbor as yourself."

Romans 13:8-9 NASB

Let no debt remain outstanding, except the continuing debt to **love** one another, for whoever **loves** others has **fulfilled the Torah**. The commandments, "You shall not commit adultery," "You shall not murder," "You shall not steal," "You shall not covet," and whatever other command there may be, are summed up in this one command: "**Love** your neighbor as yourself."

Jesus' second-first command from the Torah has an important relationship to the golden rule: You shall love your neighbor as yourself ("as you love yourself").

The implied "as you love yourself" was interpreted in various ways in Second Temple Jewish literature.

Aramaic Targum Pseudo-Jonathan on Lev. 19:18 "You shall love your neighbor, so that what is hateful to you, you shall not do to him. I am the Lord."

Adapted from Cathcart, Kevin, et al. eds. (1994). [*Targums Neofiti 1 and Pseudo-Jonathan: Leviticus \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Michael Glazier.

This interpretive translation has a direct relationship to a famous teaching of Rabbi Hillel, one of the most influential Rabbis in the time of Jesus (quoted in Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 31).

"There was another case of a gentile who came before Shammai. He said to him, 'Convert me on the stipulation that you teach me the entire Torah while I am standing on one foot.' He drove him off with the building cubit that he had in his hand.

He came before Hillel: 'Convert me.'

He said to him, "'What is hateful to you, to your fellow don't do.'" That's the entirety of the Torah; everything else is elaboration. So go, study."

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 127.

James (Ya'akov) the apostle made this direct connection from Jesus' teaching.

James 2:8 Instructor's Translation

But **if you fulfill the royal law** as expressed in this Scripture, "You shall love your neighbor as yourself," you are doing good.

So then, what Jesus goes on to explore is precisely how love is expressed in six different case studies. For Jesus, genuine love is righteousness. If we practice the way of love, we will, by nature, do right by other

people.

Reflection Question

How would you describe Jesus' relationship to the Torah?